



Washington State of the Girl Report 2026

Presented by Girl Scouts of Western Washington

Mission Statement

The State of the Girl Report exists because data has the power to drive change, but only when it is gathered with intention, interpreted with integrity, and shared in service of the girls it represents. This report is more than a collection of statistics. It is a commitment to seeing girls fully: their strengths, their challenges, and the structural conditions that shape their lives from early childhood through young adulthood.

Girls across Washington State navigate school and healthcare systems that were not always designed for them, unintentionally overlooking their unique needs and potential. This report names opportunities for improvement as an initial step towards better representing girls in Washington.

When communities, policymakers, and educators can see where girls are thriving and where they are falling behind, they are better equipped to make decisions that reflect the full picture. Disaggregated and accessible data allows for a deeper understanding of which populations are needing more support.

The girls of Washington are already demonstrating extraordinary resilience. They are graduating, leading, and advocating for one another despite persistent structural barriers. This report honors that resilience while opening the door for positive impact. The goal is to increase awareness and action with this report for every girl, in every community in Washington State.

**Sharing the lived
experiences of
Washington girls.**

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Key Findings

Structural gaps persist, even as girls continue to outperform.

Resilience is not a substitute for support.

Girls in Washington graduate at higher rates than boys, show increasing school engagement, and are seeking mental health care at growing rates. Girls are outperforming despite structural gaps in healthcare access, STEM opportunity, and safety. Celebrating resilience without addressing the conditions that demand it risks obscuring the work still that still needs to be done.

Girls are increasingly engaged in school, but not all girls feel they belong.

Aggregated data hides girls who need support.

Averages do not communicate the full facts. When "girls" is treated as a single category, elevated rates of depression, dating violence, and suicidal ideation among subpopulations go unaddressed. Disaggregated data is not a methodological preference; it is a matter of visibility, and visibility is a prerequisite for equitable policy.

By the time prevention reaches girls, risk behaviors are already established.

Focus more on middle school.

Nearly 1 in 4 sixth-grade girls reported contemplating suicide in 2023, and dating violence begins escalating in 8th grade, yet most prevention efforts remain concentrated in high school. Resources should shift earlier, focusing on prevention before risk behaviors are established.

Academic success alone cannot close structural gaps that determine opportunity.

Structural barriers accumulate.

The challenges documented in this report are cumulative and interconnected. A girl in a rural, low-income district faces limited access to healthcare and limited exposure to career pathways. A girl in foster care enters adolescence already managing elevated mental health needs before any individual choices are made. Girls' strong academic performance cannot explain Washington's 6th-largest wage gap; it is explained by the structural conditions that determine which opportunities become available. Improving outcomes for Washington girls requires addressing these structural barriers.

Demographics of Washington State Girls

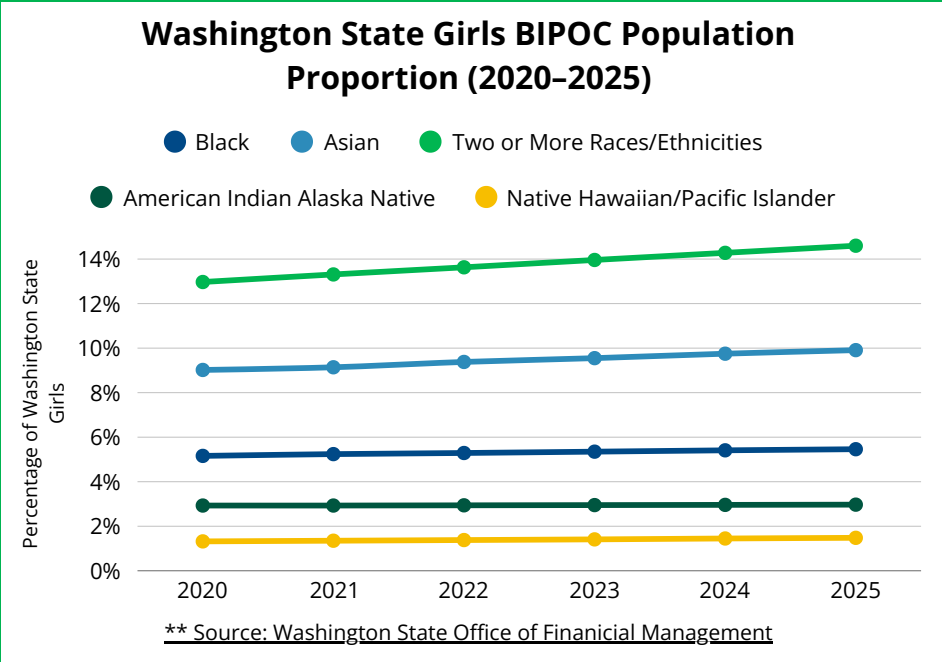
Washington is home to nearly **one million girls under the age of 20**, each with unique strengths and circumstances shaped by where they live, their demographics, and the opportunities available to them. This report brings together data on the statistics, experiences, and outcomes of girls across our state, to better advocate for every girl in every community.

The majority of Washington girls identify as white, while more than one in three identify as girls of color. Girls identifying as two or more races/ethnicities make up the second-largest group at 14.6%, reflecting the state's growing diversity.

Washington State Girls by Race and Ethnicity (2025)

Race/Ethnicity	Population	Percent
White	606,837	65.58%
Black	50,539	5.46%
American Indian/Alaska Native	27,479	2.97%
Asian	91,732	9.91%
Native Hawaiian/Pacific Islander	13,651	1.48%
Two or more races	135,127	14.6%

Source: Washington State Office of Financial Management*



Source: Washington State Office of Financial Management*

The share of BIPOC girls in Washington has grown steadily across all non-white racial and ethnic groups since 2020. Girls of two or more races/ethnicities represent the largest and fastest-growing BIPOC segment, approaching 15% of the total girls population in 2025.

*To explore the full dataset, navigate to State Data Tables > 2020–2025 state data tables for population figures, or Race and Hispanic Origin > Postcensal race and Hispanic origin estimates: 2020–2025

Physical Health | Overview

Physical health indicators for girls in Washington highlight key trends in activity, safety, and access to care. Many girls still face barriers to meeting recommended physical activity guidelines and accessing preventive care. Structural factors such as rural healthcare access and early life experiences also shape long-term health outcomes.

Physical Health Risks and Trends

Many girls in Washington are not meeting key physical health benchmarks. Data from the Washington Healthy Youth Survey shows that **only 38% of 10th grade girls meet the recommended 60 minutes of daily physical activity.** Early health experiences also matter: over **one-third of youth report at least one Adverse Childhood Experience (ACE)**, which can influence health outcomes and sense of safety. Health outcomes vary across communities. Access to healthcare services is not evenly distributed across Washington, with rural areas facing fewer healthcare providers and longer travel distances to care.

Injury and Preventable Health Outcomes

The **leading causes of death in Washington for girls ages 10–19 are accidental injury, suicide, and homicide.** Unlike many adult health risks, deaths in adolescence are more often linked to injuries or other external causes rather than chronic disease. These patterns highlight the importance of prevention, safety education, and early intervention in supporting girls' long-term health.

Key Takeaways

1. Only 38% of 10th-grade girls meet daily physical activity guidelines.
2. Over one-third of Washington girls have experienced at least one Adverse Childhood Experience (ACE).
3. Accidental injury, suicide, and homicide are the top three causes of death for girls ages 10–19 in Washington.

Physical Health

Girls’ physical health in Washington State reflects both progress and gaps across early health foundations, physical activity, sleep, injury, and access to care. Using data from the Washington Healthy Youth Survey, the Washington Department of Health, CDC datasets, and environmental health indicators, we assess where girls are meeting health benchmarks and where structural gaps persist.

Early Health Foundations

Over one-third of Washington girls report at least one Adverse Childhood Experience.*



Disparities often begin early in life through chronic conditions, environmental conditions, and income status. Chronic conditions such as asthma, Adverse Childhood Experience (ACE) exposure, and inconsistent preventive care access shape long-term health trajectories.

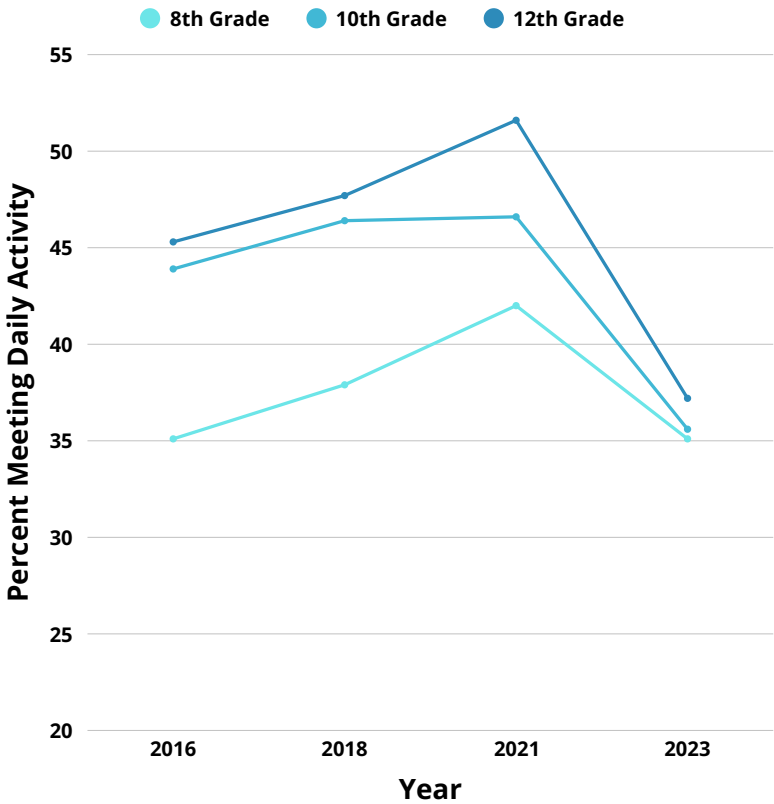
In Washington:

- 23.9% of youth report one ACE
- 12.1% report two or more ACEs

This means over **one-third of youth report at least one adverse childhood experience.**

[What is an adverse childhood experience?](#)

Physical Activity By Grade



Source: Healthy Youth Survey*

*To access Healthy Youth Survey Data, navigate to the data dashboard and select the corresponding year, grade, topic, and measure.

Physical Activity & Sleep

National guidelines recommend **60 minutes of daily physical activity**, yet only a minority of high school girls meet that benchmark. Sleep patterns also decline during high school, with **fewer girls reporting 8 or more hours per night.**

While some indicators declined sharply during the pandemic and have slightly improved, many have not returned to earlier levels.

Only 38% of 10th grade girls in Washington meet the recommended 60 minutes of daily physical activity.

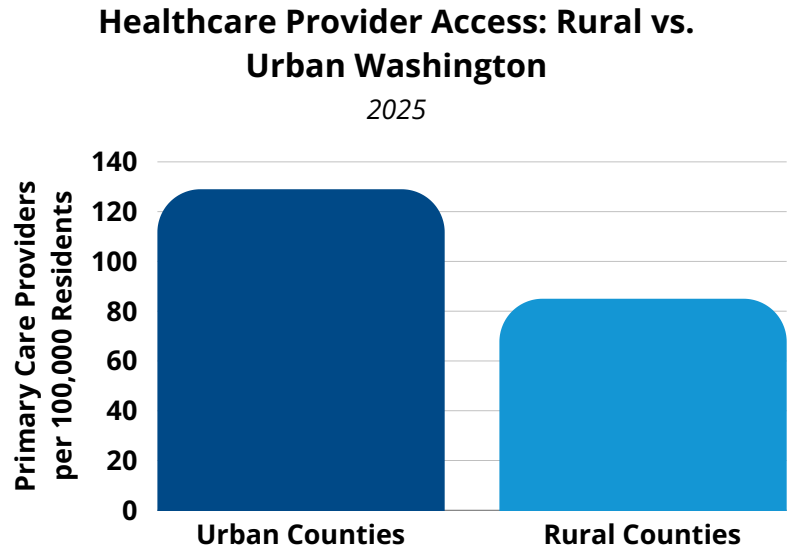


Geographic & Access Gaps

Where a girl lives significantly shapes her access to healthcare. Rural counties face:

- **Fewer pediatric providers**
- **Longer travel distances**
- **Limited confidential adolescent services**

Urban regions may offer stronger provider density but face environmental stressors such as pollution and higher housing instability. Workforce shortages may further widen geographic health disparities.

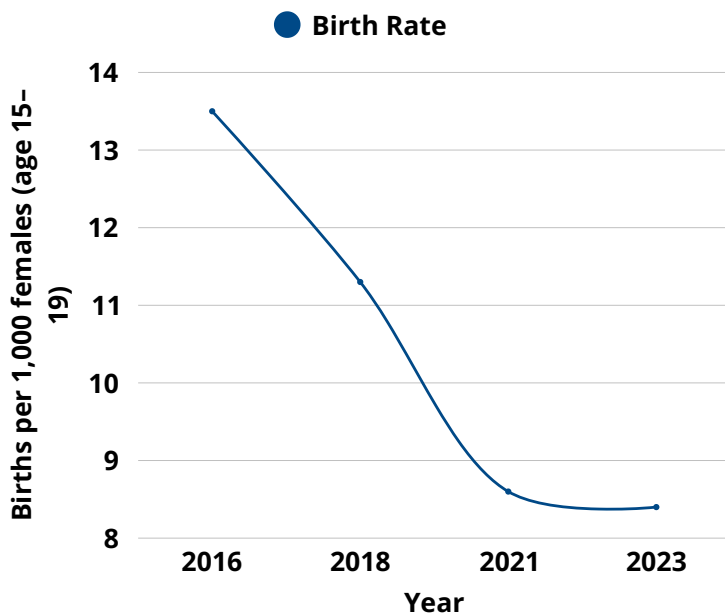


Source: WA State Department of Health & UW Center for Health Workforce Studies

Access to reproductive healthcare varies significantly between rural and urban communities in Washington.



Washington State Teen Birth Rate (Ages 15–19)



Source: Washington State Department of Health*

*To explore the full dataset, navigate to Data & Statistical Reports > Washington Tracking Network > Birth Outcomes Data > All Births Dashboard and filter by Age 15–19.

Reproductive Care

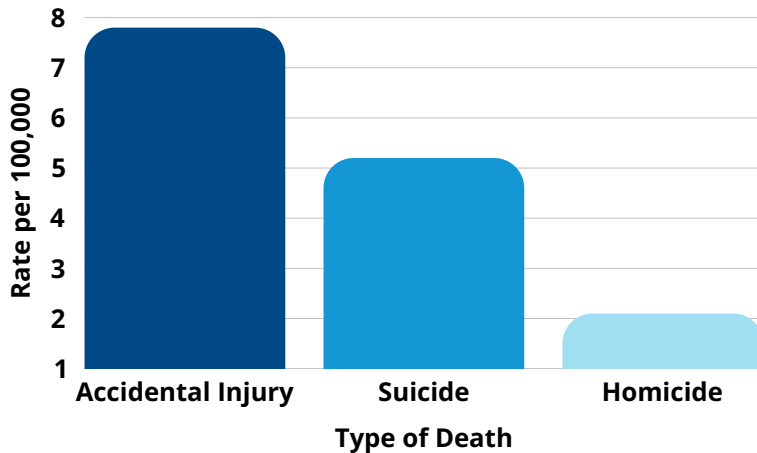
Preventive healthcare access strongly influences long-term outcomes. In 2022, there were **2,144 live births to girls ages 15–19 in Washington**. Teen birth rates, STI rates, and annual checkups reflect access to care and health education.

Girls without confidential access to reproductive care are less likely to seek early screening or preventive services.



Injury & Mortality

Leading Causes of Death for Washington Girls (Ages 10–19)
2024



Source: CDC WONDER – Mortality Data

For girls ages **10–19** in Washington, the leading causes of death include:

- **Accidental injury**
- **Suicide**
- **Homicide**

Accidental injuries, particularly motor vehicle incidents, remain a major physical safety risk. Unlike adult mortality, where chronic disease dominates, adolescent deaths are largely external and preventable.

Although mortality rates are low compared to adults, deaths in this age group are more likely to result from external causes rather than disease. These patterns help inform prevention and safety strategies .

**To explore the full dataset, navigate to Underlying Cause of Death 2018–2024 and group by Cause of Death. Filter by State: Washington, Age: 10–19, and Sex: Female. Under cause of death, select "113 Selected Causes" and choose Accidents (unintentional injuries), Intentional self-harm (suicide), and Assault (homicide).*



Many injuries among adolescents **are preventable** through safety education and community prevention efforts.

Call to Action for Washington State Girls

1

Promote Physical Activity for Girls

Many girls in Washington fall short of recommended daily physical activity levels. Schools should shift PE models toward lifetime fitness skills over competitive sports, with inclusive programming that keeps girls engaged through high school.

2

Improve Access to Preventive Healthcare

Healthcare access varies widely across Washington, with rural communities facing provider shortages and long travel distances. Expanding school-based health centers and telehealth would bring care directly to girls who need it most.

3

Strengthen Safety Education

Accidental injuries are a leading cause of death among adolescent girls. Expanding safety education and prevention programs can reduce these risks and improve health outcomes.

Emotional Health | Overview

Mental illness indicators for girls in Washington declined during the COVID-19 pandemic. Despite some improvement by 2023, mental illness indicators in girls remain elevated compared to pre-pandemic levels in 2016 and 2018.

Anxiety, Depression Are Widespread, but Slowly Improving

Rates of anxiety in Washington girls are still high, with **nearly 1 in 2 senior girls meeting the criteria for Generalized Anxiety Disorder statewide.**

Depression is also widespread: **in 2023, 35.1% of 8th-grade girls in Washington reported depressive symptoms.**

Anxiety and depression in Washington State girls peaked in 2021, however rates of both are on a gradual decline, **a hopeful sign that girls' mental health overall may be slowly but surely improving.**

Disparities and Support Barriers Persist

Data shows significant mental health disparities across race/ethnicity and sexual orientation. **LGBTQ+ and gender and sexuality questioning girls and American Indian/Alaska Native girls experience depressive symptoms at higher rates,** suggesting that more intentional supports for marginalized groups are needed.

Additionally, many girls are lacking crucial support: **roughly 1 in 8 sophomore and senior girls in Washington reported they did not have a trusted adult.**

Key Takeaways

1. Mental health is improving, but remains worse than pre-pandemic levels.
2. Anxiety and depression remain widespread among girls.
3. Support gaps and disparities for mental health symptoms and treatment persist, especially for marginalized girls.

Emotional Health

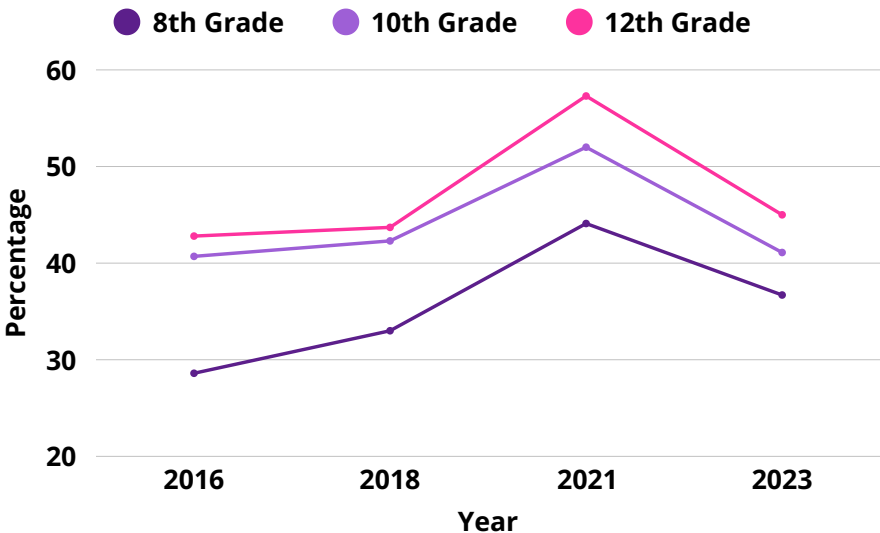
Anxiety

Nearly **1 in 2** senior girls met criteria for **Generalized Anxiety Disorder** in 2023.



Rates of anxiety in girls appear to have peaked immediately after the COVID-19 pandemic began, and although on a downward trend, still remain elevated in comparison to 2016 rates.

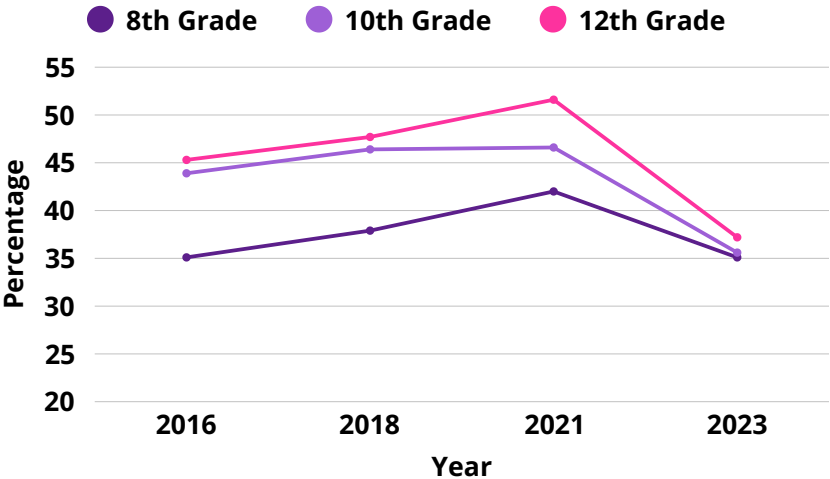
Washington Girls Meeting Generalized Anxiety Disorder Criteria



Source: Healthy Youth Survey.

Depression

Washington Girls Reporting Depressive Symptoms



Source: Healthy Youth Survey.

Depression rates followed a similar trajectory leading up to the pandemic, however, unlike anxiety, depressive symptoms in Washington State girls have dipped back **below 2016 rates** as of 2023.

Data also indicates that contemplation of suicide is more common in girls in **early middle school** than in **high school**. Suicide prevention and education efforts may need to expand to target a wider age range, including **early adolescence**.



Nearly **1 in 4** 6th grade girls in Washington reported contemplating suicide in 2023.



Support Gaps

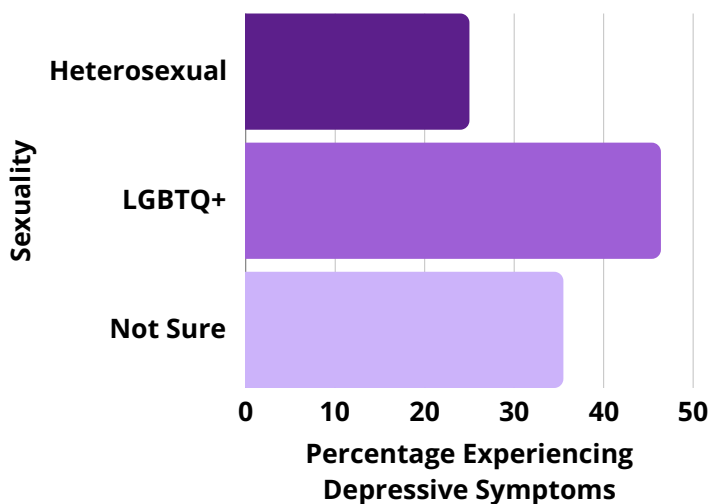
There are substantial disparities in depression rates across **racial/ethnic groups** and **LGBTQ+ identities** in Washington State youth.



In King County:

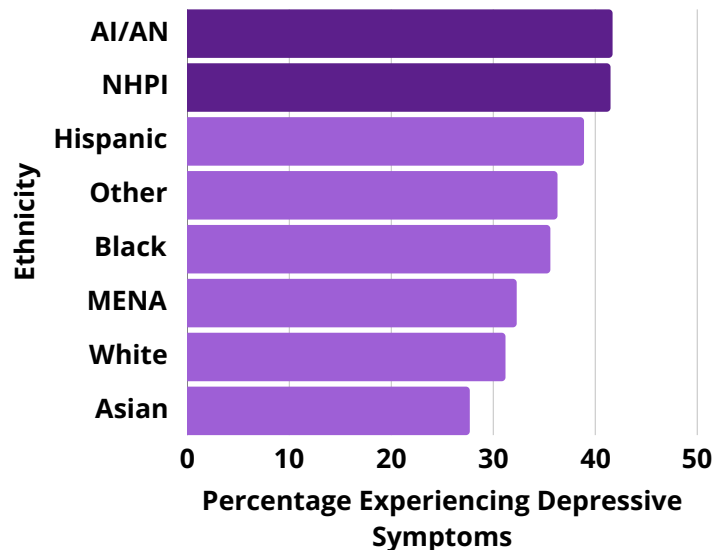
- **46.4% of LGBTQ+ girls** and **35.5% of girls unsure of their sexuality** reported depressive feelings in 2023.
- **American Indian/Alaska Native** and **Native Hawaiian/Pacific Islander** girls had the highest rates of depressive symptoms (41.7% and 41.5%) in 2023.

Depressive Feelings in King County Girls by LGBTQ+ Identity
2023



Source: Communities Count

Depressive Feelings in King County Girls by Ethnicity
2023



Source: Communities Count

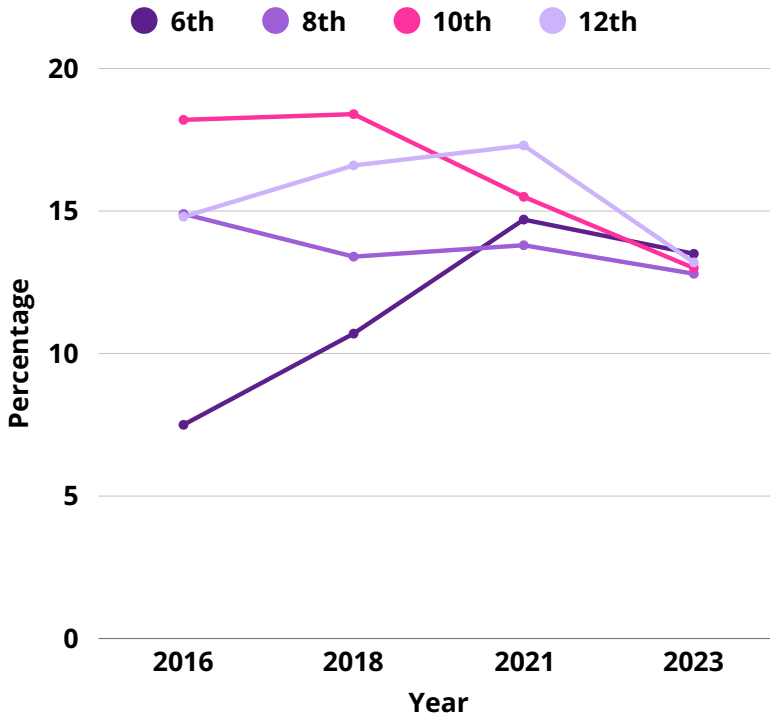
While statewide and county-level girl-specific data is limited, available statewide data for all youth show similar disparities, with BIPOC and LGBTQ+ youth reporting higher rates of depression, anxiety, suicidal ideation and attempts than their white and heterosexual peers.

This suggests that more **targeted, affirming, and culturally sensitive** support is needed for **girls of color** and **LGBTQ+ girls**.

Roughly **1 in 8** high school girls in Washington State **did not have an adult to turn to when depressed** in 2023



Washington Girls Reporting No Adult to Turn to When Depressed



Source: Healthy Youth Survey.

Given elevated rates of mental health struggles among girls in Washington, trusted adult support is especially important.

Although the percentage of girls lacking support has declined over time, **too many girls still lack a reliable adult when they need one most.**

Consistent, caring adult relationships are a well-established protective factor against poor mental health outcomes in adolescents.

Call to Action for Washington State Girls

1

Invest in Early Mental Health Prevention

Suicidal ideation is already high by early middle school. Screening, prevention, and mental health education need to begin in early adolescence to account for this.

2

Expand Culturally Affirming Mental Health Support

BIPOC and LGBTQ+ girls suffer higher rates of mental illness symptoms. Culturally responsive, identity-affirming care is needed.

3

Close the Trusted Adult Support Gap

Mentors, counselors, and supportive school staff are protective factors for girls' mental health. Funding relationship-based youth supports should be a priority.

Social Wellness | Overview

School environments, peer relationships, and digital spaces shape girls' social wellness in Washington. While many girls demonstrate strong engagement in school, disparities remain for those with behavioral health needs or limited community resources. Strengthening supportive relationships, inclusive school practices, and healthy social environments can help ensure that all girls feel connected and supported.

Social connection and belonging are important

Supportive school environments, positive peer relationships, and trusted adult connections act as protective factors against mental health challenges, substance use, and isolation.

Some girls face structural barriers to belonging.

Girls with behavioral health needs, neurodivergent girls, and those in under-resourced communities may experience **lower engagement, higher online vulnerability, or greater risk behaviors**, highlighting the need for inclusive support systems.

Engagement trends show progress, disparities remain

The percentage of Washington girls who "always care about doing well in school" rose from 57.3% (2021-22) to 63.5% (2023-24), higher than the statewide average and boys' rates. Despite this, girls with behavioral, emotional, or developmental challenges and neurodivergent girls often report lower engagement and face exclusionary discipline, highlighting gaps in school support.

Key Takeaways

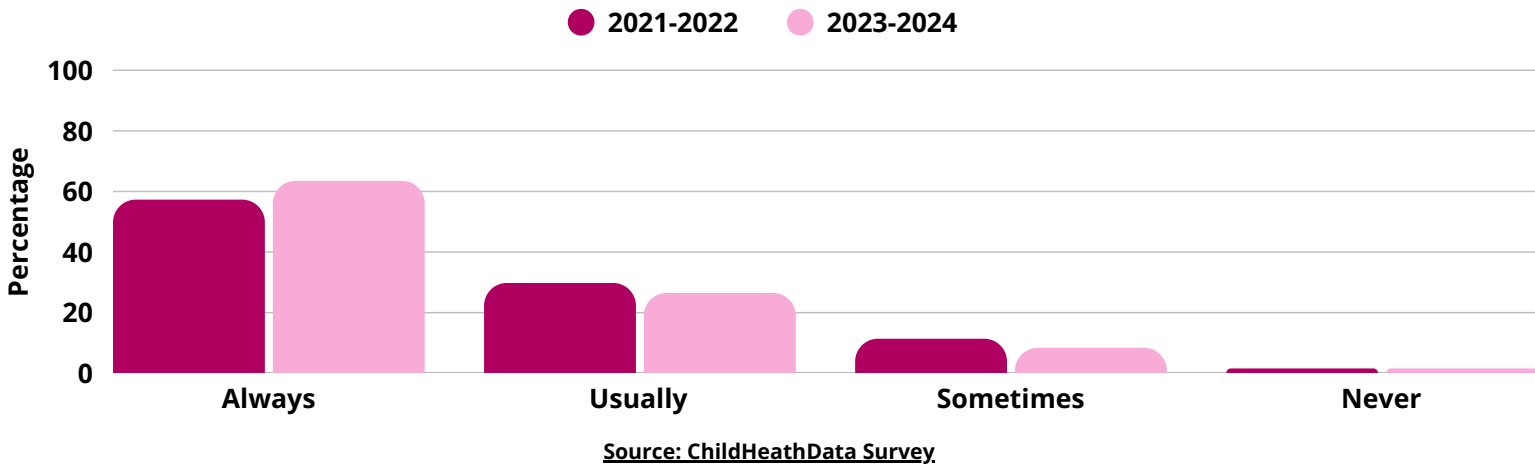
1. Positive trends in girls' school engagement show resilience.
2. Vaping use reflects social context and stress.
3. Problematic internet use intersects with social vulnerabilities.

Social Wellness

School Belonging and Engagement

School connectedness is one of the strongest protective factors against suicide, substance use, and other behavioral health challenges among youth. Supportive relationships with teachers and staff play an important role in fostering this sense of belonging, as students who feel cared for by adults at school are more likely to remain engaged academically and socially.

Washington Girls Age 6-17 Caring About School & Doing Homework



Girls in Washington report increasing engagement in school, with those who say they 'always care about doing well in school' **rising from 57.3% in 2021-22 to 63.5% in 2023-24**, higher than both the statewide average (56.4%) and rates reported by boys. However, engagement is not evenly experienced: among Washington youth with emotional, behavioral, or developmental health needs, **43.2% report being sometimes or never engaged in school and 33% report being only usually engaged**.

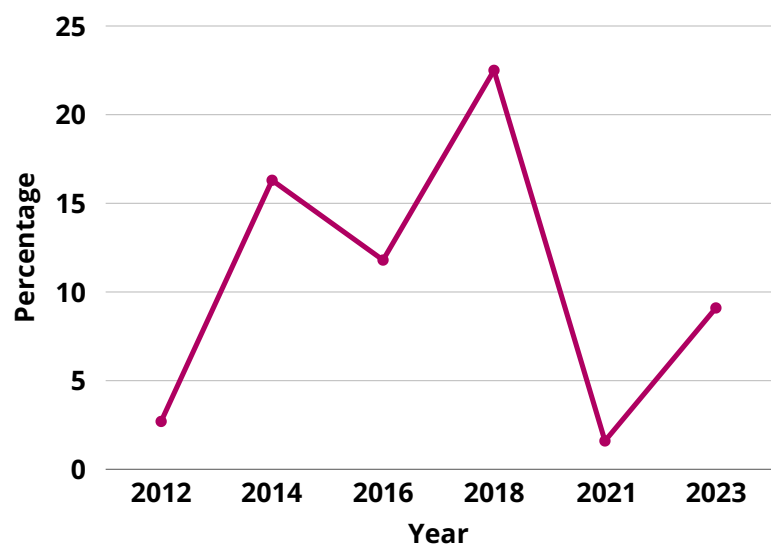
These barriers to belonging may be especially significant for **neurodivergent girls**, particularly those with ADHD or autism, who are often mischaracterized as disruptive and may face exclusionary discipline instead of support.

The data suggests that while many girls in Washington demonstrate strong academic engagement, **barriers to belonging may still exist for girls with behavioral or developmental needs**, highlighting the importance of inclusive school environments that foster connection for all students.

E-Cigarette Usage

E-Cigarette usage among adolescent girls reflects more than a health behavior, it is often shaped by peer dynamics, social stress, and community context. Due to a majority of vapes containing nicotine, this can harm the parts of an adolescent's brain that control learning, attention, mood, and impulse control due to a majority of vapes containing nicotine. Girls in Washington State are now consistently using e-cigarettes more than their male peers.

Statewide Usage of E-Cigarettes for 10th Grade Girls

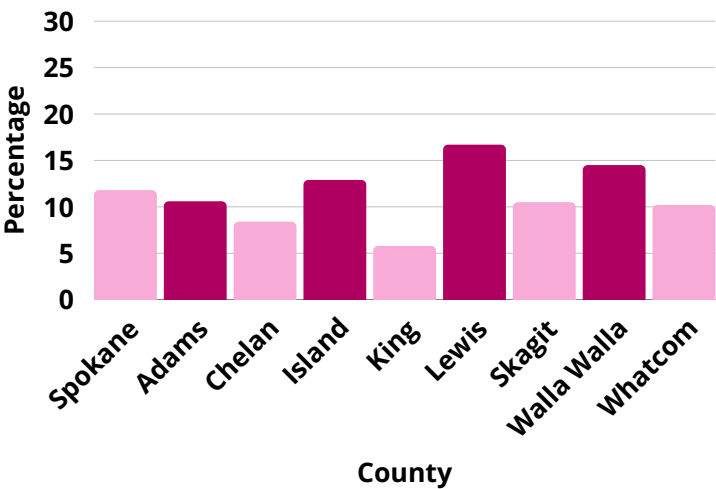


Source: Healthy Youth Survey.

Statewide e-cigarette usage among 10th grade girls dropped from 22.5% in 2018 to 8.9% in 2021, while slightly increasing in 2023. Though data for 2019–2020 are missing due to COVID-19, and pandemic-related changes in social behavior may have contributed to the decline.

County-level data shows disparities in e-cigarette use among girls in Washington. While the statewide average in 2023 was 9.1%, King County remains below this level, potentially reflecting stronger access to school and community supports. For some girls, vaping may serve as a way to cope with stress or fit into peer groups.

10th Grade Girl's Current E-Cigarette Usage by County in 2023



Source: Healthy Youth Survey.

Access to supportive social environments, like strong school programs, extracurricular opportunities, and community resources, reduces risky behaviors like e-cigarette use.

Problematic Internet Use

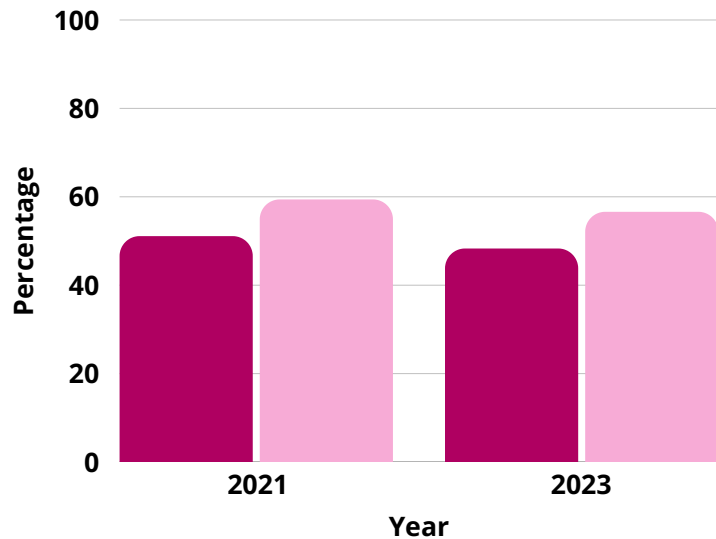
Girls in Washington consistently report higher rates of problematic internet use (defined as excessive, impulsive, or uncontrolled internet usage that leads to significant impairment in daily life) than boys and exceeding the United States averages. Students with emotional or learning disabilities report significantly higher rates of problematic internet use compared to others.

Nearly 1 in 3 teens use social media **“almost constantly.”**



These patterns are notable because youth with emotional or developmental challenges already face greater barriers to school engagement and belonging, suggesting that problematic internet use may intersect with broader social and behavioral health vulnerabilities for girls.

8th and 10th Grade Washington Teen Girls at Risk for Problematic Internet Usage



Source: Healthy Youth Survey.

Call to Action for Washington State Girls

1

Strengthen supportive relationships in schools

Prioritize mentorship, trusted adult relationships, extracurriculars clubs, and inclusive classroom practices so girls feel supported and connected to their school environments.

2

Expand inclusive resources for students

Provide training and resources that help educators better support neurodivergent girls and students with behavioral health needs, reducing exclusionary discipline and promoting belonging.

3

Promote healthy peer and digital environments

Support digital wellness education and provide structured extracurricular opportunities that encourage positive peer relationships and reduce reliance on unhealthy coping behaviors such as substance use or excessive internet use.

Academic & Career Outcomes | Overview

Girls in Washington demonstrate strong on-time high school graduation rates and assessment performance in English language arts. However, disparities persist in math and science proficiency, particularly across low-income and rural districts, and participation in Career and Technical Education pathways. While strong academic performance opens doors, other factors can influence long-term economic opportunity.

Girls Excelling Academically, but Gaps Persist:

Girls graduate on time at higher rates than boys and are more likely to finish with a GPA above 3.0. However, boys outperform girls in math and science proficiency, **the gap has grown since COVID-19, from under 1% to over 3%.**

Career Pathways Reflect Occupational Segregation

Girls are concentrated in Career and Technical Education (CTE) pathways tied to care, education, and service fields associated with lower lifetime earnings. They remain underrepresented in STEM, trades, and technical programs that **lead to higher wages and credential completion within six years after graduation.**

Academic Success Doesn't Close the Wage Gap

Washington has the sixth largest wage gap in the U.S. Even controlling for education level, women earn significantly less than men pointing to structural educational barriers that academic achievement alone cannot overcome.

Key Takeaways

1. Girls excel academically but trail in math and science, especially in rural and low-income school districts.
2. Girls cluster in certain career pathways from high school onward.
3. Washington's wage gaps persists regardless of education level.

Academic & Career Outcomes

Academic Performance in K-12

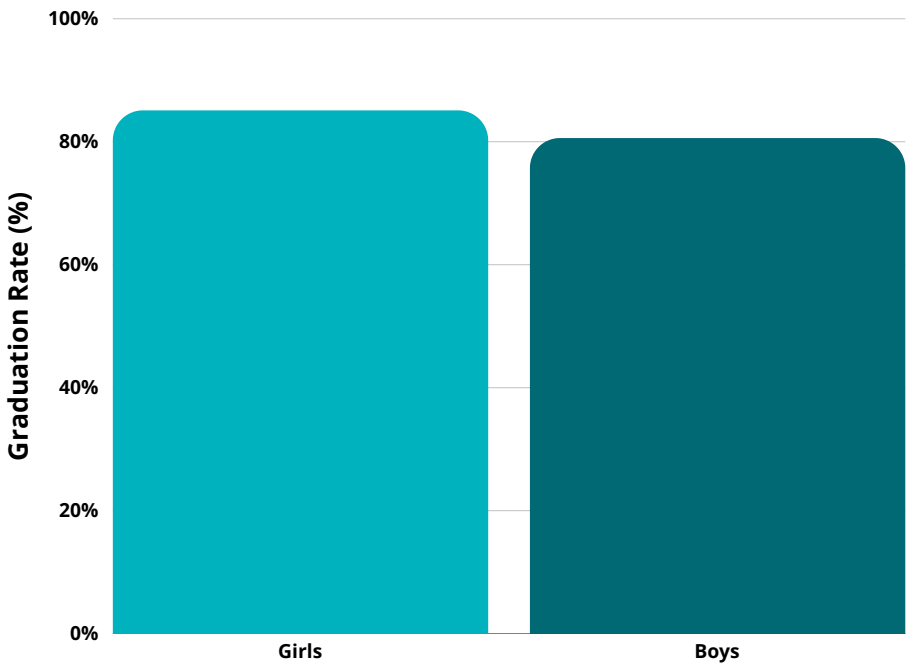
51% of girls graduate with a GPA above 3.0 compared to 36% of boys.



Girls (**85.1%**) tend to graduate on time at higher rates than boys (**80.6%**) across Washington.

While graduation rates reflect overall academic success, they do not capture differences in subject proficiency. The charts below show the share of students meeting state standards in English language arts, math, and science.

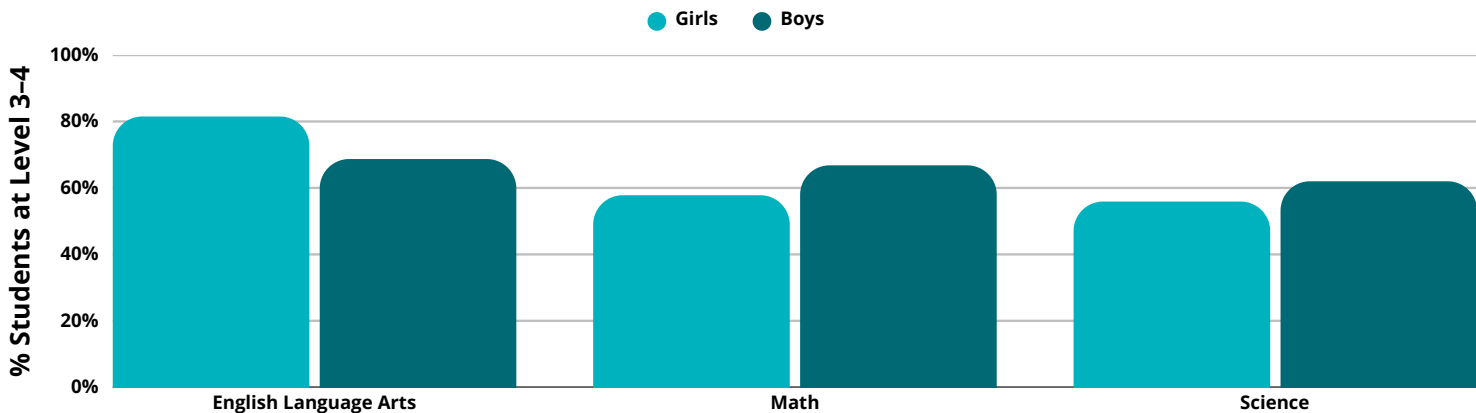
On-Time High School Graduation Rates by Gender
2024-25 School Year



Source: Washington OSPI Report Card

Percent of Students Meeting Level 3-4 Proficiency by Gender (2024-25)

L3 = consistent grade-level knowledge | L4 = advanced grade-level knowledge



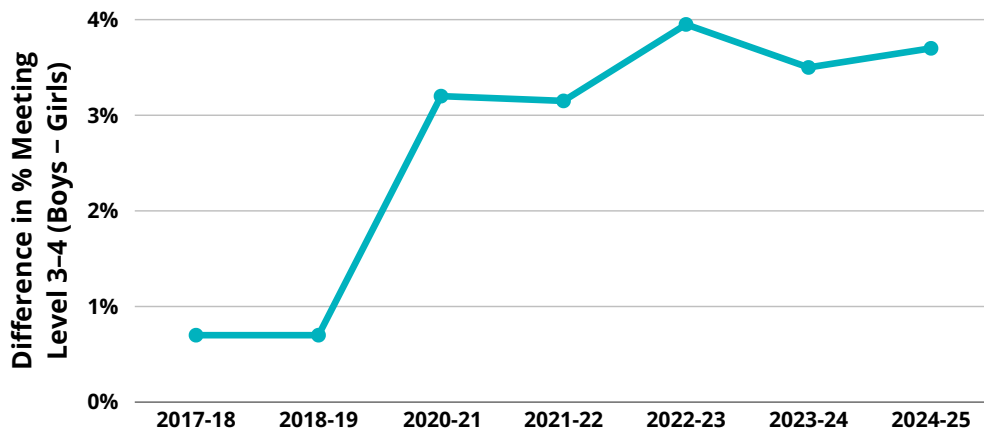
Source: Washington OSPI Report Card

While girls meet proficiency at higher rates in English language arts, boys meet proficiency more often in math and science. This may reflect differences in classroom experiences or access to subject-specific learning opportunities.

Values show the yearly proficiency gap in math and science (boys minus girls).

Difference in Boys' and Girls' Level 3–4 Proficiency in Math and Science

Data not gathered in the 2019–2020 school year due to COVID-19.



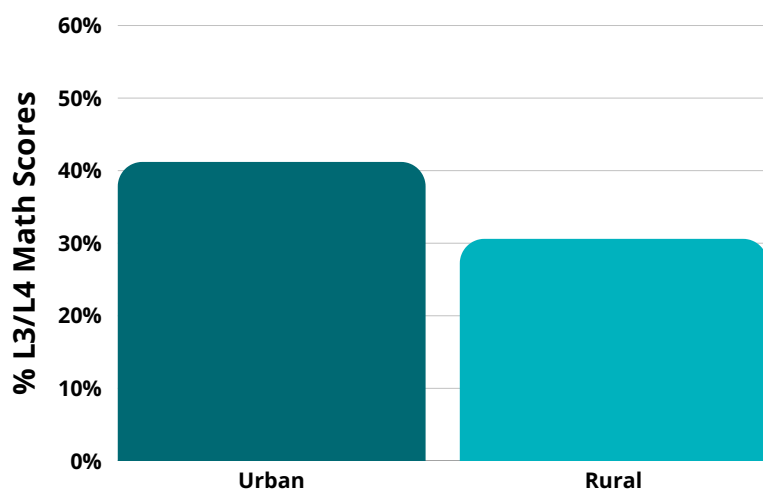
Source: Washington OSPI Report Card

(Author Analysis of OSPI Report Card Data)

The graph shows how the gender gap in math and science proficiency has grown since 2017–18. **After statewide testing resumed post-COVID-19, the difference increased from 1% to 3%.** While girls demonstrate strong academic performance overall, disparities are growing in STEM-related subject proficiency.

Percent of Girls Meeting Level 3-4 Proficiency in Math (2024-25)

Urban vs. Rural Districts



Source: Washington OSPI Report Card

(Author Analysis of OSPI Report Card Data)

Low-income Districts (>20%)



Source: Washington OSPI Report Card

(Author Analysis of OSPI Report Card Data)

Girls in districts with higher rates of low-income students tend to have lower math proficiency rates compared to other districts. Similarly, rural districts often experience lower math proficiency than urban districts.

These patterns suggest that broader structural conditions such as school resources, course availability, and access to academic support may shape learning opportunities.

Differences in opportunity, geography, and other structural barriers—not just whether girls graduate—can influence economic futures.

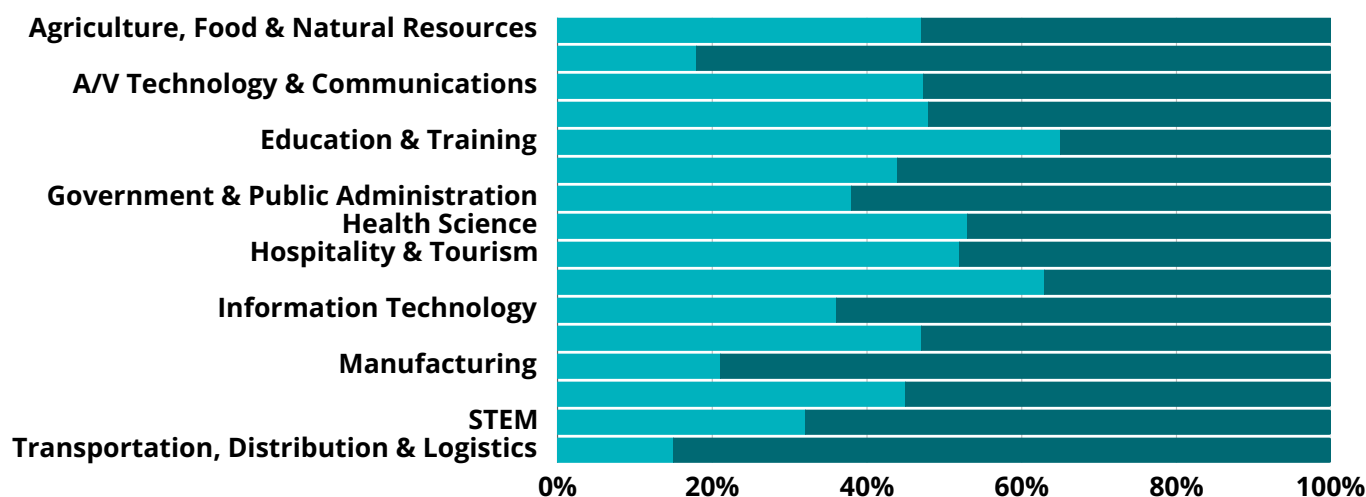
Career & Technical Education (CTE) Participation

Career and Technical Education (CTE) programs connect high school learning with career exploration and workforce preparation. Enrollment patterns across career clusters provide insight into gender differences in career pathways beginning during high school.

CTE Participation Ratio by Gender and Career Cluster

2023-24 School Year

Girls Boys



Source: Perkins Collaborative Resource Network

Girls are most represented in fields traditionally associated with care, service, and education, including **Education (65%)**, **Human Services (63%)**, **Health Science (53%)**, and **Hospitality and Tourism (52%)**. They are underrepresented in technical and industrial pathways such as **Architecture and Construction (18%)**, **Manufacturing (21%)**, **Transportation (15%)**, and **STEM (32%)**.

These patterns mirror broader occupational trends in the labor market and may influence the industries and wage levels girls experience later in life. Differences in early career pathways can shape access to long-term earnings and opportunities for economic mobility.

Women are concentrated in lower-paying occupations like sales (\$36K) and service (\$27K) roles.



Women's different distribution across occupations and industries accounts for half of the wage gap.

Median earnings are highest in male-dominated fields and lowest in female-dominated ones at the same skill levels.



Male-dominated pathways increase the likelihood of earning a credential and living wage six years after high school.

Long-Term Economic Context

Median Earnings and Women-to-Men Earnings Ratios by Education Level

 ¹⁰	Women	Men	Ratio
Less than High School Diploma	\$24,400	\$32,000	76.3%
High School Diploma or Equivalent	\$32,400	\$42,000	77.1%
Some College Education	\$38,000	\$50,000	76%

Washington has the 2nd largest wage gap in the U.S.A.



Across education levels, women earn less than men. **In Washington, women with some college education earn about \$4,000 less annually than men with only a high school diploma.**

Differences in STEM proficiency, disparities across low-income and rural districts, and patterns in CTE enrollment all shape the educational pathways girls experience. Together, these factors can influence the careers girls pursue and their long-term economic opportunities.

Call to Action for Washington State Girls

1

Fund Teacher Training To Close the STEM Gap

Teaching methods matter. Invest in ongoing professional development that equips educators with strategies to engage all students in math and science.

2

Resource Schools to Diversify CTE Enrollment

Course decisions happen early. Support school and community programs that help girls explore the range of career paths before choosing courses.

3

Support Policies That Address the Wage Gap

Support policies and enforcement efforts that advance pay equity and hold employers accountable.

Safety | Overview

Safety indicators for girls in Washington reveal persistent disparities in school safety, dating violence, and support systems. **Structural factors such as school climate, adult support, and foster care** involvement shape how safe girls feel at school, in relationships, and in systems meant to protect them.

Weapons and Feeling Unsafe

In Washington, weapon carrying is highest among students who report feeling unsafe at school. Available data shows disparities by gender identity and disability status, but **data limitations make it difficult to fully disaggregate by gender across all subgroups**. When data is broken down, disparities emerge clearly. One-size-fits-all safety approaches fail our most vulnerable students.

Dating Violence Escalates Without Early Intervention

Dating violence nearly doubles between middle school and senior year.

1 in 13 senior girls has felt unsafe with a dating partner. For **LGBTQ+ girls, the risk is nearly twice as high**. Prevention efforts remain focused on high school, missing middle schoolers.

Foster Girls Face Compounding Crises

Girls in foster care **ages 12–17 are twice as likely to need mental health treatment**, with over 80% struggling by adolescence. They face higher rates of bullying, dating violence, and school instability.

Key Takeaways

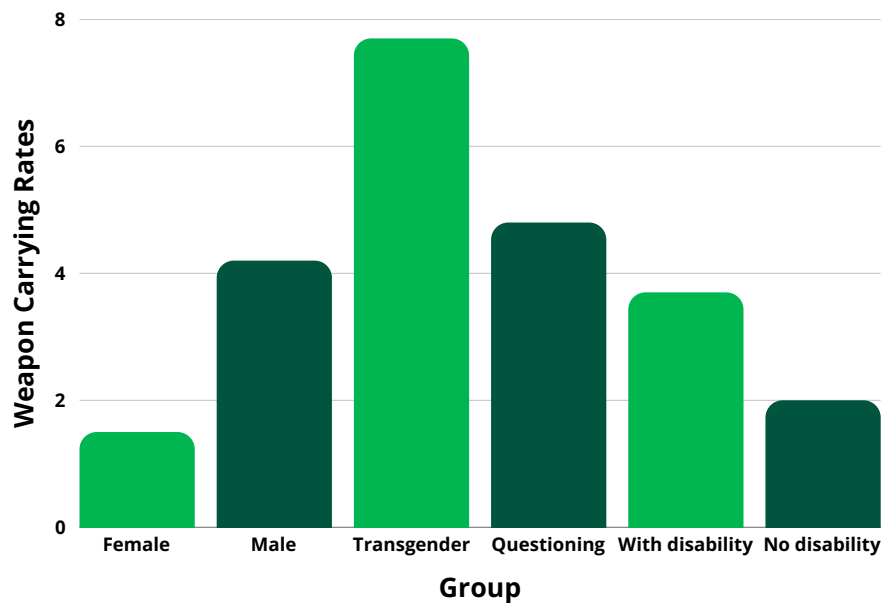
1. One-size-fits-all approaches fail girls with the highest risk of feeling unsafe.
2. Safety risks begin escalating in middle school.
3. Bullying and dating violence compound the crisis of instability for girls.

Weapons

2,275 weapon incidents were reported in Washington public and private schools during the 2022-23 school year: an 11.6% increase from the previous year. Of those, **316 involved a firearm, all at public schools.**

Weapon Carrying at School by Group

12th Grade Violent Behaviors & School Safety for Washington State, 2023



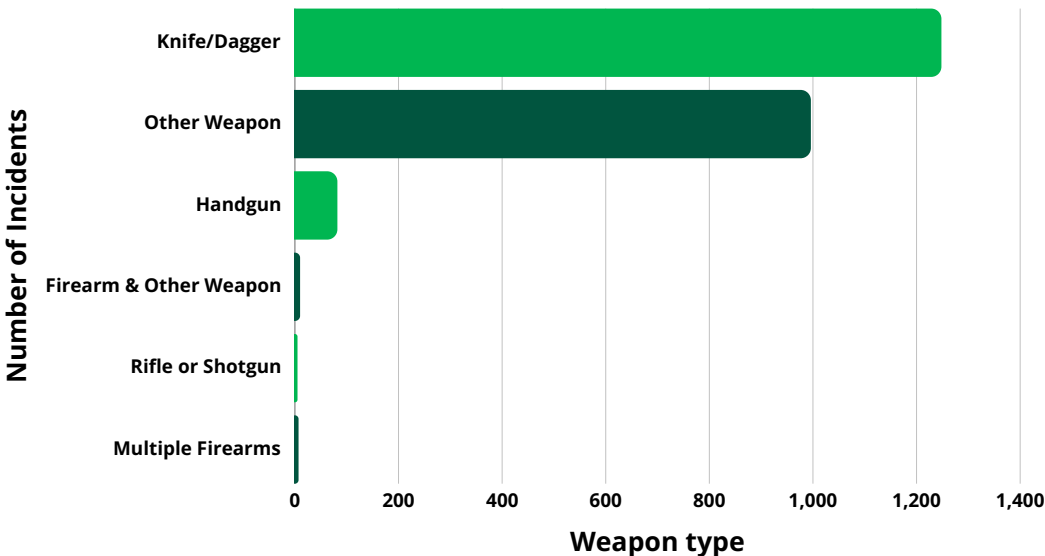
Source: Healthy Youth Survey, 2023

Students who feel most vulnerable at school report higher rates of weapon-carrying, suggesting these **students may be arming themselves in response to feeling unsafe rather than posing a threat.**

Other weapons include protective spray devices, air guns, tasers, and metal knuckles.

Weapons Brought to School

Washington public and private schools, 2022-23



Source: OSPI Weapons in Schools Report, 2024

Dating Violence

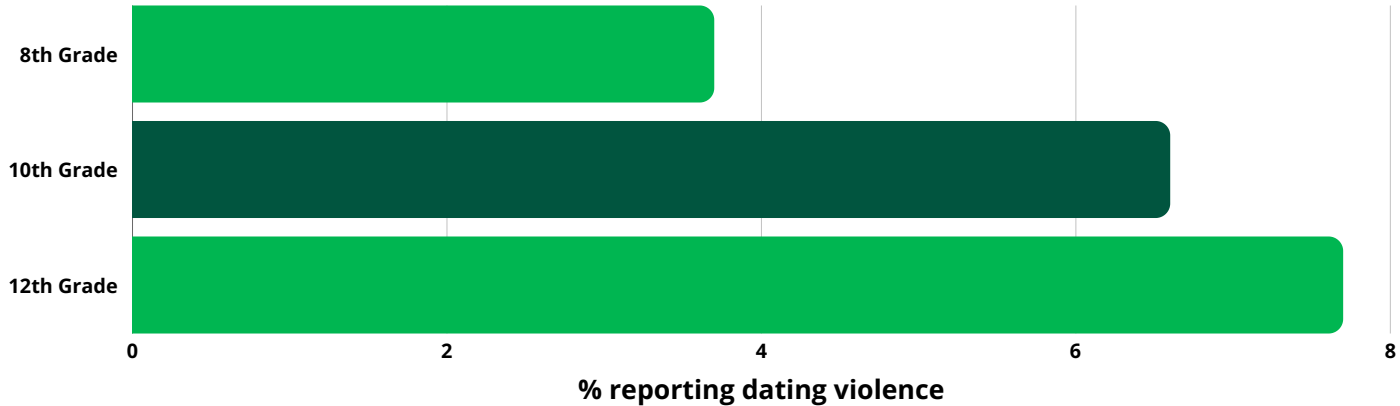
Dating violence nearly doubles between middle school and senior year. The **CDC (2023) reports that teen girls are experiencing record-high rates of violence.**

Washington's data shows: risk escalates as girls get older, yet prevention efforts lag. The girls most unsafe at school are often the most unsafe in relationships.



King County Dating Violence by Grade, Washington Girls

Percent who report being controlled, threatened, or made to feel unsafe by a dating partner, 2023



Source: Communities Count / Healthy Youth Survey, 2023

Dating Violence Disparities by Sexual Orientation

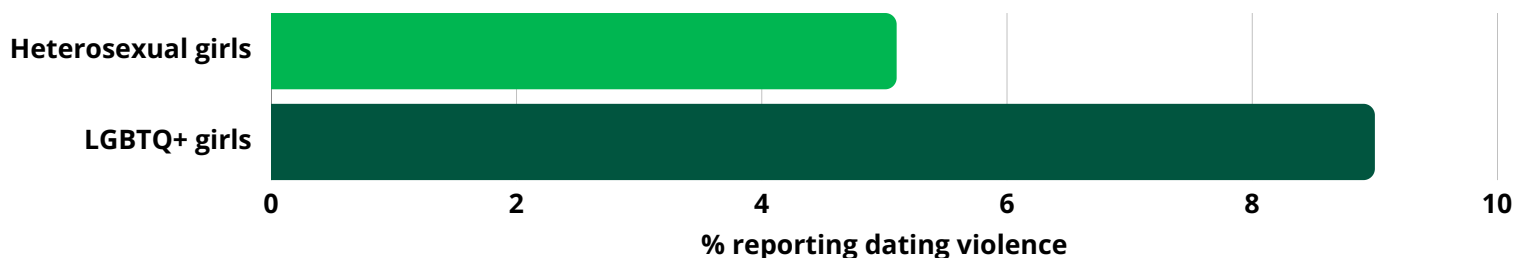
A girl's sexual orientation predicts her risk of dating violence. **LGBTQ+ girls without affirming spaces face higher rates of victimization**, and without trusted adults, abuse goes undisclosed and escalates. Research suggests **safe, inclusive schools may reduce their vulnerability to violence.**



Schools that affirm LGBTQ+ identities **create the trust girls need to report abuse early**, making them a direct prevention tool.

King County Dating Violence by Sexual Orientation

Percent of girls who report dating violence, 2023



Source: Communities Count

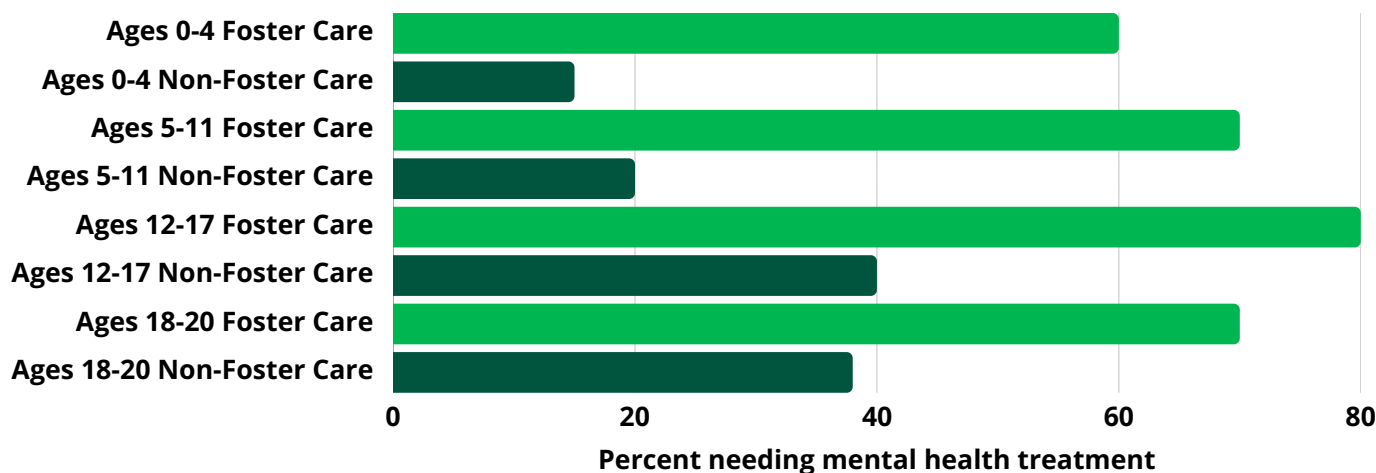
Foster Care Disparities

A girl in foster care, aged 12–17, is twice as likely to need mental health treatment as her peers. **By adolescence, 80+% of foster girls are struggling with mental health needs, compared to 40% of their peers.** These same girls face higher rates of bullying, unsafe relationships, and school instability. Safety is not just about physical harm. It is about **whether a girl has the support she needs to survive and thrive.** For foster girls, that support is rarely there.



Foster Care Disparity, Washington Girls

Safety includes mental health — girls in foster care ages 12–17 are 2x more likely to need care, 2025



Source: Washington Thriving Report, 2025

Call to Action for Washington State Girls

1

Train All Staff in LGBTQ+ Affirming Practices

Districts must require annual, evaluated training so every adult can identify dating violence and support LGBTQ+ students before harm escalates.

2

Fund GSAs and Visible Safe Spaces in Every School

Every school needs funded student groups and trained staff students can identify by name. Trusted relationships are what make reporting possible.

3

Create Safer Environments for Every Student

Invest in school climate initiatives that address root causes of fear, especially for transgender students and students with disabilities.

Our Beacons of Hope

Washington is home to many organizations that support youth. Some are intentionally designed to address the distinct needs of girls, highlighting a foundation to build on and service gaps to address.

Girl Scouts of Western Washington, Eastern Washington, and Southwest Washington: provides leadership development, belonging, life skills, outdoor experiences, and confidence-building for girls throughout Washington.

Physical

- **Girls on the Run of Puget Sound:** supports girls through movement-based social-emotional learning, confidence, and healthy relationships.

Social/Emotional

- **Camp Fire:** inclusive development, leadership, and social-emotional growth.
- **Washington School-Based Health Alliance:** Health equity and school-based health centers.
- **Northwest Youth Corps:** youth leadership, conservation, and workforce pathways.
- **YMCA of Greater Seattle:** focused on wellness, safety, leadership, and youth programming.

Safety

- **TeamChild:** supports youth at risk of involvement with juvenile justice and welfare systems.
- **Treehouse:** for girls in foster care; focuses on educational, material, and financial support.
- **YouthCare:** supports young people experiencing homelessness, including girls.
- **The Mockingbird Society:** youth-led systems advocacy, focused on child welfare.
- **Youth Against Sexual Violence:** youth-led related to prevention and survivor support.

Academic/Career

- **Believe in Me:** supports youth facing poverty, trauma, isolation, and systemic barriers
- **Boys & Girls Clubs:** after-school access, safety, belonging, and enrichment for girls.
- **Big Brothers Big Sisters:** one-to-one mentoring and protective adult relationships.
- **College Success Foundation:** college and career access support for underserved students.
- **Cougs 4 Kids:** mentorship and leadership development for marginalized youth.
- **Girls Inc. of the Pacific Northwest:** focused on leadership, education, and helping girls.
- **Glover Empower Mentoring (GEM):** mentoring, justice, education, and case management.
- **MENTOR Washington:** statewide mentoring backbone organization.
- **School's Out Washington:** strengthens afterschool and learning systems.

Washington Thriving: Statewide effort to plan for equitable behavioral health for children.

Methodology & Data Limitations

The Washington State of the Girl Report compiles metrics across five core areas: Physical Health, Emotional Well-being, Social/Behavioral Health, Academic/Career Readiness, and Safety. Data visuals present comparisons and disparities across grade levels, sexual orientations, race and ethnicity, disability status, foster care involvement, and geographic regions using publicly available state and national sources.

Agency Data

This report cites national research for context across all five content areas: CDC YRBS and WONDER for Physical Health; the Trevor Project (2023) for Emotional Well-being and Safety; peer-reviewed ACEs research and social media data for Social/Behavioral Health; national wage gap research for Academic/Career Readiness; and Stop AAPI Hate (2023) for disaggregated AAPI Safety data. Cited research is contextual only and does not replace Washington-specific data.

Data Collection

Data sources include the Washington State Healthy Youth Survey, Communities Count, Washington State Department of Health, Washington State Health Care Authority, Washington State Department of Social and Health Services, Office of Superintendent of Public Instruction, CDC YRBS, CDC WONDER, Washington Tracking Network, Child and Adolescent Health Measurement Initiative, Education Research and Data Center, and the Status of Women in Washington report. All data is anonymized; no primary research was conducted.

Disaggregating Data

To understand differences among girls in Washington, data are disaggregated by grade level, sexual orientation, race, ethnicity, disability status, foster care involvement, and county where available. The ability to disaggregate is limited by the availability of statewide data; this report acknowledges its inability to fully capture all intersectionalities of the target audience.

Where data is suppressed to protect confidentiality, it is noted accordingly.

Accuracy

All reasonable efforts were made to ensure accuracy. Metrics may be under-reported or unavailable, and data from different sources should not be compared due to differing methodologies.

About the Authors

Natalie Cohen

Natalie contributed to the Physical Health section of this report, examining physical activity trends, early health foundations, geographic access gaps, and injury and mortality patterns among girls across Washington. She analyzed data from the Washington Healthy Youth Survey, the Washington State Department of Health, and CDC WONDER mortality data.



Isabelle Henderson

Isabelle conducted research on the academic and career outcomes of Washington state girls and their demographic splits. She analyzed online data from the Washington State Office of Financial Management and the Washington Office of Superintendent of Public Instruction, focusing on academic performance, CTE program participation, and long-term wage gaps.



Kelvyn Joaquin

Kelvyn contributed to the Safety section of this report, examining disparities, dating violence escalation, foster care mental health gaps, and identity-based risk among girls across Washington. He also supported data verification and source citation across the report, ensuring findings were accurately attributed and grounded in publicly available research.



Ashley Moua

Ashley contributed to the visual design and branding of the report, including the cover page, headers, and footers. In addition, she conducted research on social wellness and compiled data from the Healthy Youth Survey and ChildHealth Data identifying trends in school engagement, substance use, and internet use for the Social Wellness section.



Hannah Rose

Hannah conducted research for and created the Emotional Health section of the report, compiling and visualizing data from the Healthy Youth Survey and Communities Count to analyze trends and support gaps in areas including depression, anxiety, and suicidality. She also led the formatting and design of the report, ensuring consistent styling, layout, and visual coherence.



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Well Balanced Center

Well Balanced Center guides organizations to improve quality of life outcomes by developing and managing effective programs that create lasting, measurable impact. Specializing in program strategy, design, management, and personalized experiences that support individuals and communities achieve long-term personal and professional growth. The Well Balanced Center has supported organizations such as School-Based Health Alliance and the IF Project by leading trainings and programs that have impacted thousands of people and those they serve via a myriad of tools and resources.



WMarketplace

The WMarketplace Inc. is a women-led business consulting and training company dedicated to advancing economic opportunities for women entrepreneurs and small business owners. Through partnerships with government agencies, corporations, nonprofits, and economic development organizations, The WMarketplace delivers programs focused on digital skills, e-commerce, exporting, and AI adoption. The company has supported thousands of women-owned businesses across the United States and internationally, including initiatives for underserved communities and Ukrainian women entrepreneurs. The WMarketplace combines research, education, and mentorship to help women build sustainable businesses, increase economic participation, and strengthen pathways to leadership and financial independence in the digital economy.



MARKETPLACE
The Economic Engine for Women



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**To access specific Healthy Youth Survey Data, navigate to the data dashboard and select the corresponding year, grade, topic, and measure.*